The Tale of Despereaux

By Kate DiCamillo

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NARRATOR: This story begins within the walls of a castle, with the birth of a mouse. The only one of his litter to be born alive.

MOTHER: Just the one. It is such the disappointment. I will name this mouse Despereaux, for all the sadness, for the many despairs in this place. Now, where is my mirror?

NARRATOR: The other, older mice children gathered around to stare.

BROTHER: Look, his eyes are open. They shouldn't be open.

NARRATOR: Despereaux's eyes should not have been open. But they were.

FATHER: He'll be dead soon. He can't live with his eyes open like that.

NARRATOR: But he did live. This is his story.

INTRODUCTION

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NARRATOR: Despereaux Tilling lived, but his existence was cause for much speculation in the mouse community.

AUNT: He's the smallest mouse I've ever seen. No mouse has ever been this small.

UNCLE: Those are some big ears he's got.

AUNT: They are obscenely large.

NARRATOR: Despereaux said nothing in defense of himself. Everything they said was true. And he was sickly. He coughed and sneezed so often that he carried a handkerchief in one paw at all times.

TRANSITION: Despereaux discovered a sound. The sound was music. King Phillip playing his guitar to his daughter, the Princess Pea. Hidden in a hole in the wall the mouse listened.

DESPEREAUX: Oh, it sounds like heaven. It smells like honey.

NARRATOR: Now, Despereaux did adhere to one of the most basic of all mice rules: Do not ever reveal yourself to humans. But…The music made him lose his head, and he was spied by the Princess Pea.

PEA: Oh, look, a mouse.

KING: That my dear Pea, is a bug, not a mouse.

PEA: No, no, it's a mouse. I think he was listening to the music. Play something Papa.

KING: A king play music for a bug?

PEA: I told you, he's a mouse.

KING: Oh, well, if it will make you happy, I will play music for a bug.

NARRATOR: Despereaux forgot all his fear. He only wanted to hear the music. The princess smiled at Despereaux, and Despereaux smiled back. The mouse fell in love.

TRANSITION: Despereaux's brother happened to scurry past the princess's room. He saw the princess touching the top of his brother's head.

BROTHER MOUSE: He's nuts! He's a goner!

PEA: Papa, I am going to keep this mouse.

KING: A mouse? Mice are rodents. They are related to rats. You know of our own dark history with rats.

PEA: "But, he is not a rat. He's a mouse.

KING: Put him down. Scat!

PEA: "Please, don't be mean to him.

DESPEREAUX: My name is Despereaux! I honor you!

KING: Get out! Rodents know nothing of honor.

NARRATOR: Despereaux's brother went off to tell his father the terrible news of what he had just seen.

LESTER: He simply cannot be my son.

ANTOINETTE: What do you mean he is not your son? That is a ridiculous statement. Why must you always make the ridiculous statements?

LESTER: Sitting at the foot of a human king. Unthinkable!

ANTOINETTE: Oh, so dramatic.

LESTER: I will call a special meeting of the Mouse Council. Together, we will decide what must be done.

ANTOINETTE: Oh, you and this council of the mouse. It is a waste of the time in my opinion.

TRANSITION: The mouse council gathered in a secret hole. The mice listened in horror while Despereaux's father related the story of what Furlough had seen.

HM: Despereaux Tilling.

NARRATOR: Said the head mouse.

DESPEREAUX: Yes, sir.

HM: We, the members of the Mouse Council have discussed you behavior. We will give you a chance to defend yourself against these rumors of your egregious acts. Did you or did you not sit at the foot of the human king?

DESPEREAUX: I did.

HM: Did you allow the girl human to touch you?

DESPEREAUX: I did, sir. Her name is Pea. But..

HM: Very well. We have no choice. You will die.

NARRATOR: Despereaux marveled at his own bravery. He admired his own defiance. And then, he fainted. Two mice came forward.

MOUSE: We will escort you to the dungeon.

ANTOINETTE: What will happen to him? What will happen to my baby?

MOUSE: The rats will eat him. (Antoinette swoons)

TRANSITION: Together the three mice traveled down. Despereaux was suddenly pushed from behind. It sent Despereaux flying down the stairs into the dungeon.

NARRATOR: As our story continues, we must go backward in time to the birth of a rat, a rat called Roscuro, a rat born in the darkness of the dungeon. Roscuro showed an abnormal interest in illumination. He was always on the lookout for light. His rat soul longed for it. The door to the dungeon was flung open and a brilliant shaft of light cut into the dark of the dungeon.

ROSCURO: Beautiful. I must see more light. I must go upstairs.

TRANSITION: Imagine having spent your life in a dungeon. One day, you step out of the dark and into a world of bright windows and polished floors.

ROSCURO: I will never leave. No, It is here that I belong.

NARRATOR: The rat waltzed from room to room until he found himself at the banquet hall. He looked and saw King Phillip, Queen Rosemary, the Princess Pea, and all the king's men.

ROSCURO: Oh. Suffering is not the answer. Light is the answer.

NARRATOR: Roscuro flung himself onto the lowest branch of the chandelier. The Princess Pea spotted him.

PEA: A rat is hanging from the chandelier!

ROSCURO: Rat….

NARRATOR: It became clear that it was an extremely distasteful syllable. This revelation hit Roscuro with such a force, that it made him lose his grip on the chandelier. The rat fell. Right into the queen's bowl of soup.

PEA: See? It is a rat. He is in Mama's soup!

NARRATOR: In the spirit of honesty, I must utter a difficult and unsavory truth: Rats are not beautiful creatures.

QUEEN: Nneiggghhhiiinnnnkkkkk! There is a rat in my soup!

NARRATOR: The queen was a simple soul and always had done nothing but state the overly obvious. She died as she lived. Soup was outlawed in the Kingdom of Dor.

ROSCURO: I will make the princess suffer for how she looked at me.

(SCENE BREAKE)

COOK: This is what you do. You take the tray of food down to the dungeon, wait for the man to eat the food, and then you bring the tray back up. Do you think you can manage that?

NARRATOR: Said Cook.

MIG: Aye, I reckon so.

NARRATOR: Said the serving girl, Mig.

COOK: I'm sure you'll find a way to bungle it.

NARRATOR: Mig went happily down the twisting stairs.

MIG: I ain't the Princess Pea / But someday I will be, / The Pea, ha-hee
Someday, I will be.

ROSCURO: May I detain you for a moment? (Mig looks around) Down here.

MIG: You're a rat ain't you?

ROSCURO: There is no need to panic. How do you do.

MIG: A rat with manners.

ROSCURO: Allow me to introduce myself. I am Roscuro. Am I right in ascertaining that you have aspirations?

MIG: What?

ROSCURO: Aspirations, my dear, are those things that would make a serving girl wish to be a princess.

MIG: A princess is exactly what I want to be.

ROSCURO: May I illustrate for you how we can make your dream a reality?

NARRATOR: Neither noticed as a napkin on the tray moved, nor did they hear the small mouse like noises of outrage that issued from that napkin as Roscuro went on unfolding his diabolical plan.
Mig, after her conversation with Roscuro, carried the tray into the kitchen. Despereaux tumbled out of the napkin.

COOK: Kill him!

NARRATOR: Shouted Cook.

MIG: (chop) I missed him. I got the little meecy's tail, though.

COOK: So? What good will that do us when the rest of him has disappeared into the pantry?

NARRATOR: Despereaux cried for what he had lost. But he also cried because he was happy. He was out of the dungeon just in time to save the Princess Pea from the terrible

fate that the rat had planned for her.

TRANSITION: Roscuro put his terrible plan into effect. The serving girl Mig climbed the stairs to the princess's room. In her pockets were the rat and a knife.

ROSCURO: Do I need to review with you again our plan?

MIG: I got it straight right here in my head.

ROSCURO: How comforting.

MIG: We go into the princess's room and I will wake her up and say "you must come with me." We take her to the deep downs and we gives me some lessons in how to be a princess and when we is all done studding up, I gets to be princess!

NARRATOR: The sun rose and Despereaux awoke. But he awoke too late. The princess was gone. Having heard Roscuro's plan, Despereaux knew that the princess was hidden in the dungeon. So the small mouse slipped out of the pantry. Desperaux: "I will be the knight in shining armor. It has to be me.

COOK: A mouse! For the first time, I am glad to see a mouse. A mouse is not a king's man here to punish me for making soup. A mouse. A mouse with a needle tied around his waist. Ho-hee. That is soup you are smelling.

NARRATOR: She took a saucer and spooned some soup into it and set it on the floor. Oh, it was lovely. He drank the soup and when he stepped out of the saucer, his whiskers dripping.

COOK: You must want more.

DESPEREAUX: I don't have time. I'm on my way to the dungeon to save the princess.

COOK: Well don't let me stand in your way.

TRANSITION: Despereaux stood at the top of the dungeon.

DESPEREAUX: "Oh my."

NARRATOR: `But his heart was full of love for the princess and Despereaux felt brave and strong.

RAT: Welcome, welcome. You are armed. How charming. I surrender!

DESPEREAUX: I don't want to hurt you. I'm… I am on a quest to save the princess.

RAT: How inspiring. What if I told you that I that I could take you directly to her?

DESPEREAUX: But why? You are a. . .

RAT: A rat, yes. Come, come. I will lead you to your princess. I promise.

(Scene Break)

DESPEREAUX: Princess! Princess, I have come to save you!

PEA: Despereaux.

NARRATOR: But Roscuro, baring his teeth, blocked the mouse's way.

MIG: Don't worry, princess, I will save the meecy. (Chop) Whoopsie

NARRATOR: Roscuro turned to look at where his tail had been and Despereaux drew his needle and placed the sharp tip right where the rat's heart should be.

DESPEREAUX: Don't move.

ROSCURO: Ha…what is that smell? There's something…Soup.

PEA: Roscuro, …would you like some soup.

ROSCURO: Don't torment me.

PEA: I promise you that if you lead us out of here, I will get Cook to make you some soup.

ROSCURO: Soup?

PEA: Yes. Truly I promise. Let's go upstairs. Let's eat some soup.

NARRATOR: Imagine a king and princess, serving girl and a rat, all gathered in a banquet hall. Sitting in the place of honor, is a very small mouse with big ears. Peeking out from behind a curtain, are mice.

ANTOINETTE: He lives, he lives!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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